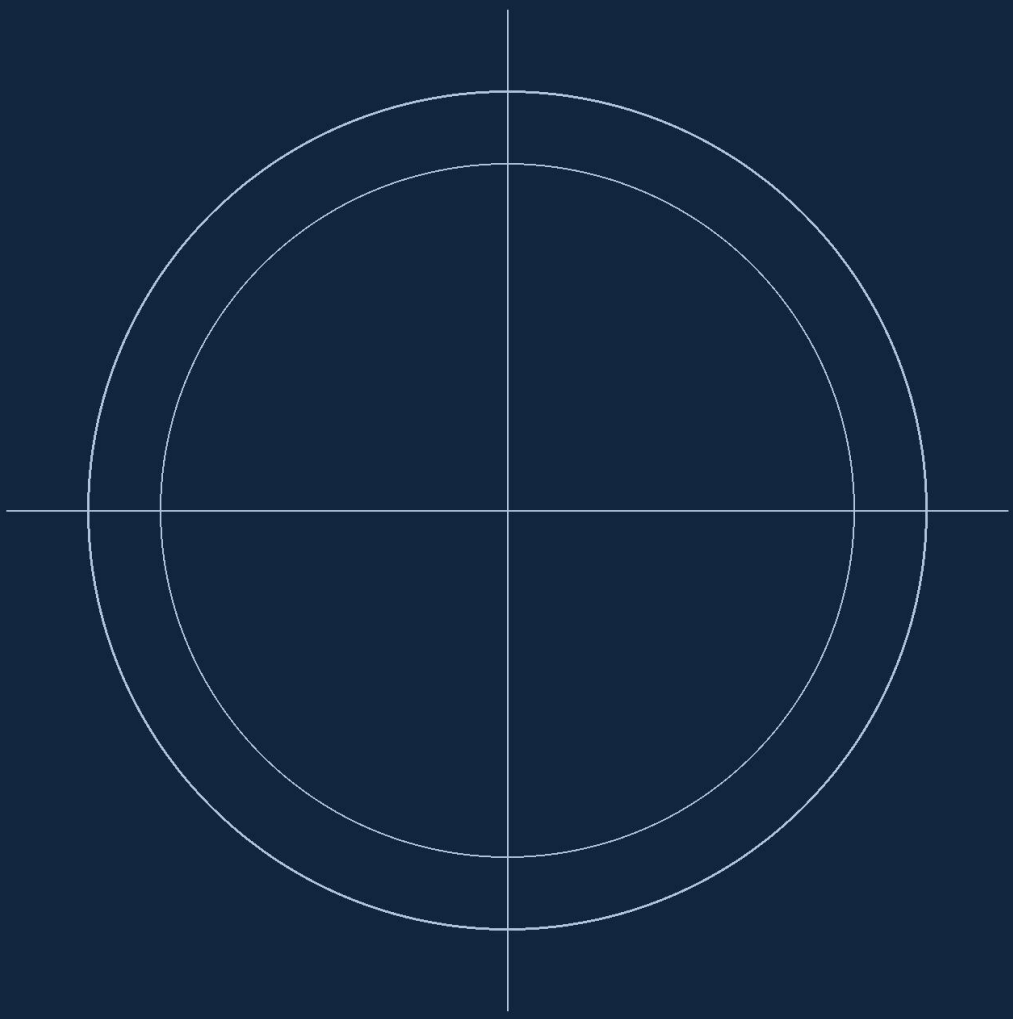


The End of the Lost

COMMENTARY COLLECTION

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1. Preface: The Question and the Position

This volume argues a position. It does not gather what churches say about the end of the lost and leave the reader to choose. It says what the author believes Scripture reveals, it sets the verses in the order they stand, and it answers the strongest objections from named modern writers, so that a reader who disagrees knows where the disagreement lies.

The question is old and it is asked in earnest. Three answers are given to it among those who hold that Scripture is the word of God. One holds that the lost are punished without end and are conscious in it. One holds that the lost are destroyed, and that destruction means they cease to exist, either at death or after a period of punishment. This second view goes by the names annihilationism and conditional immortality, and it is held today by a number of evangelical writers who are careful with the text. A third holds that all will at last be reconciled. This volume takes up the first two. It does not take up the third.

The position is this. The words Scripture uses for the end of the lost are not one word, and none of them settles the question by itself. Death, destruction, perishing, punishment, torment, exclusion, the second death and judgment each stand in their own passage with their own audience, and each has to be read there. A word that sometimes describes a thing coming to an end also describes, in other verses, a thing that remains in being and is ruined. Read cumulatively and each in its place, the passages that speak of final judgment tell of a punishment that cannot be reversed and does not end, and where the text says so, of an experience that continues. They do not require that the lost cease to exist.

Three things about the method. First, the volume reads the King James Version only, and every Scripture quotation is checked word for word against it. Second, each chapter opens with a claim, reads its passages in order, and closes with a short table and a list of what the volume takes from the passages, so that the reader can see what has been argued and test it. Third, where a modern writer is named, the volume says what that writer holds, in its own words, and gives the writer's words only where it has read them in a free full text.

The volume does not take up what its neighbours argue. Who is judged, where and when belongs to Volume 5 of the Prophecy & Mystery Commentary Series, Separate Courts, and to Studies 31, 49 and 68. The words for the unseen world and the lake of fire, reported as written, belong to Study 79, which takes no position and is not changed by this volume. The account in Luke 16 belongs to Parable Study 24, and the Lamb and the foundation of the world to Study 80. This volume cites those places and does not repeat them.

One boundary runs through the volume. The passages are read in the settings in which they stand. The Lord's words in the Gospels were spoken to Israel in His Kingdom ministry, and the visions of Revelation name the audience they were sent to. Neither is carried over to the Body of Christ, and nothing in this volume is a warning to the Body or a statement about its standing. What those passages reveal about the fate of the wicked is the evidence the volume uses. It distinguishes that testimony from any application to the Body.

The Thesis

Destruction language in Scripture does not by itself establish that the lost cease to exist. Its meaning is fixed by context, and the words for death, destruction, punishment, torment, exclusion, the second death and judgment are not one word. Taken together, each in its own setting, the passages on final judgment establish a punishment that is irreversible and enduring, and where the text says so, a continuing experience of it. They do not require cessation of existence. No single Greek word and no single proof text carries the case, and the volume does not rest it on one.

The thesis in five statements.

Statement	What it says	Where it is argued
1	The words for destruction and perishing describe an ending in some verses and a ruined condition of something that remains in others. The word alone does not decide.	Chapters 2 and 3
2	Where the Lord speaks of the power to destroy soul and body in hell, the text states a power, in a mission to Israel, and does not state an outcome.	Chapter 4
3	Everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord is read from its context as an enduring judicial exclusion, not from the preposition alone.	Chapter 5
4	The same word for everlasting is set on the life and on the punishment in one verse, and the passages that follow describe a fire and a worm that do not end.	Chapters 6 and 7
5	In Revelation the torment has no rest day nor night, the beast and the false prophet are still in the lake after the thousand years, and the second death is described by what the lake contains and does.	Chapter 8

A reader may test the thesis in one move. Take any verse in which a word of destruction stands, and ask three questions of it: who is addressed, what has just been said, and what does the verse say follows. The volume holds that the answers decide the meaning and that the word alone does not. If a passage can be produced in which the context itself states that the person ceases to be, the thesis is tested at that point, and the volume says in chapter 9 which passages come nearest to that and why it reads them as it does.

2. How the Case Is Argued

Claim: the question of the end of the lost cannot be settled by choosing a word and giving it one meaning. It is settled, if it is settled, by reading each passage in its own setting and letting the settings add up. This chapter fixes the terms, the settings and the standard of proof before any passage is argued.

2.1 What the two positions claim

The two positions differ on one point. Both hold that the wicked will be judged, that the judgment is just, and that it is final. Both hold that the Lord Jesus bore sin and that salvation is His gift. They differ on what the final judgment is. On the first view the punishment of the lost is without end and is experienced. On the second view the punishment is real and may be painful, but it ends in the cessation of the person, and the word eternal describes a result that lasts for ever, not an experience that goes on. The second view rests on a good deal of Scripture and it is stated by its defenders as an exegetical conclusion, not as a way of softening the doctrine. The volume treats it so.

Two cautions follow. The first is that an argument against the second view must not be an argument from feeling. That the idea is hard to bear is no reason to deny it, and that the alternative is gentler is no reason to accept it. The second is that agreement on the earlier points should be said aloud. A writer who holds that the lost cease to exist is not thereby a denier of judgment, and a reader who holds the first view should be able to say what the writer holds before answering it.

2.2 Seven terms kept apart

The passages use a number of words for what happens to the lost. They are often gathered under one heading as if they said one thing. The volume keeps seven of them apart, and asks of each passage which of the seven it uses and what it states there.

The seven terms and what each is asked.

Term	Where it stands in Scripture	What the volume asks of it
Death	Genesis 2:17; Ezekiel 18:4; Luke 15:24; Ephesians 2:1	Does the passage describe an ending of life, or a condition of a living person?
Destruction, perishing	Matthew 10:28; Philippians 3:19; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Does the verse state that the thing ceases, or that it is ruined, lost or wasted?
Punishment	Matthew 25:46; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Does the punishment last, and how does the passage say it lasts?
Torment	Revelation 14:10, 11; 20:10	Does the passage describe an experience, and does it say the experience has an end?
Exclusion	Matthew 7:23; 25:10–12; 2 Thessalonians 1:9	Is the condition described as lasting, and from what are the persons excluded?
The second death	Revelation 20:14; 21:8	What is it called, and what does the passage say it contains?
Judgment	Hebrews 6:2; Revelation 20:11–15	What is the judgment said to be, and what follows it?

The table is a list of questions, not a list of answers. Some of the passages named in it are not argued until later chapters, and some are cited and not argued at all. The point is that a verse using the second term is not read as if it used the sixth.

2.3 The setting is fixed first

A passage is read in the setting in which it was spoken or written. The settings differ, and the differences bear on what a passage can be made to say. Israel's law and prophets speak to Israel about Israel and the nations round her. The Lord's words in the Gospels were spoken to Israel in His Kingdom ministry: He sent the Twelve "to the lost sheep of the house of Israel" and commanded them, "as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand" (Matthew 10:6, 7). The letters of Paul are written to assemblies and to individuals, and their words on the end of the wicked stand in the course of an argument addressed to them. The letters that name their own readers are read for what they name. Revelation names its audience at the outset, and its visions are read as visions of events still to come.

The volume does not claim that every passage in every setting says the same thing about the lost. It claims that the settings, taken together, give a consistent account, and it tests the claim by reading each passage where it stands. A passage spoken to Israel is not treated as a command to the Body of Christ, and a passage written to an assembly is not treated as a word to Israel. What each passage reveals about the fate of the wicked is the evidence, and the audience is kept in view while it is gathered.

2.4 No single word, no single proof text

The case is cumulative. It does not rest on the Greek word for destroy, or on the word for everlasting, or on the smoke that goes up in Revelation 14, or on the worm of Mark 9. The volume does not expect any one of these to bear the weight of the question, and the reader should not be asked to believe that it does. Where the other side makes a fair point about a word, the volume says so. The point may be that destruction, in some verses, describes a thing coming to an end. It may be that everlasting, in some verses, describes a result. It may be that a fire which is not quenched does not by itself show that what is cast into it continues to burn. These are conceded where they are true, and the volume then asks what the rest of the passage and the passages beside it add.

2.5 Three marks of evidence

Each conclusion in the chapters that follow is marked as one of three kinds. A conclusion is Stated where the verse says it in so many words. It is Shown by the context where the verse does not say it but the verses around it do, or the passage it quotes does. It is Inferred where the volume draws it by reasoning from what is stated and shown. A reader who accepts the first and the second and doubts the third knows exactly what he doubts. The volume holds that the case needs all three, and that it is weakest where it is inferred. It says so at those points.

How the argument is built.

Step	What is done	Chapters
Words	The words of destruction and death are shown to be used in more than one way, and the word alone is not taken to decide	2 and 3
Texts	The passages most often cited on either side are read in their own settings, in order	4 to 7
Objections	Named modern writers on both sides are stated in their own best form and answered from Scripture	8
Conclusion	What the cumulative reading shows is stated, with what it leaves unsaid	9

What the volume takes from this chapter

- The two positions agree that the wicked are judged and differ on whether the lost cease to exist; the volume treats the second as an exegetical conclusion.
- Seven terms are kept apart, and each passage is asked which of them it uses.
- Each passage is read in the setting in which it stands, and nothing said to Israel is carried to the Body of Christ.
- The case is cumulative; no single word or proof text carries it, and fair lexical points on the other side are conceded.
- Each conclusion is marked Stated, Shown by the context, or Inferred.

3. Death, Destruction and Perishing in Their Own Contexts

Claim: the words most often cited for the end of the lost are used in Scripture of things that cease and of things that remain. The word alone does not decide which is meant. This chapter concedes what is true on the other side, shows the second use, and states what follows and what does not.

3.1 Where the words describe an ending

The words of destruction and death sometimes describe an end, and the volume says so first. Of the flood the record says, “All in whose nostrils was the breath of life, of all that was in the dry land, died” (Genesis 7:22), and in the next verse, “every living substance was destroyed which was upon the face of the ground” (Genesis 7:23). Destroyed and died stand side by side, and the destroying is the dying. When Nebuchadnezzar was angry with the wise men, he “commanded to destroy all the wise men of Babylon” (Daniel 2:12), and the destroying is killing. When the Pharisees “held a council against him, how they might destroy him” (Matthew 12:14), the word is again the word for taking life. Of the sons of Korah’s company the record is that “they perished from among the congregation” (Numbers 16:33) after the earth closed upon them.

These are plain, and an annihilationist is right to cite them. Where a verse tells of a person put to death, destroy and perish describe the death. The volume does not deny it. The question is whether that is the only use of the words, and whether a verse in which they stand beside a judgment after death must be read as these are.

Where destruction and perishing describe death.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Genesis 7:22, 23	All in whose nostrils was the breath of life, of all that was in the dry land, died. And every living substance was destroyed which was upon the face of the ground, both man, and cattle, and the creeping things, and the fowl of the heaven; and they were destroyed from the earth: and Noah only remained alive, and they that were with him in the ark.	Died and destroyed describe the same event, the end of life on the ground.
Daniel 2:12	For this cause the king was angry and very furious, and commanded to destroy all the wise men of Babylon.	The command to destroy is a command to kill.
Matthew 12:14	Then the Pharisees went out, and held a council against him, how they might destroy him.	To destroy him is to put him to death.
Numbers 16:33	They, and all that appertained to them, went down alive into the pit, and the earth closed upon them: and they perished from among the congregation.	They perished from among the congregation, as the earth closed upon them.

3.2 Where the person is lost and remains

The same family of words is used in the Gospels of persons who are not dead and who are not destroyed in the sense just seen. The Lord sends the Twelve “to the lost sheep of the house of Israel” (Matthew 10:6). The sheep is Israel, and Israel is alive. In the parable the shepherd, “having an hundred sheep, if he lose one of them, doth not leave the ninety and nine in the wilderness, and go after that which is lost, until he find it” (Luke 15:4). The sheep that is lost is a sheep in the wilderness, and when it is found the shepherd says, “I have found my sheep which was lost” (Luke 15:6). The psalmist says of himself, “I have gone astray like a lost sheep; seek thy servant” (Psalm 119:176), and he is the one speaking.

The prodigal is spoken of in the same way. The father says, “this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found” (Luke 15:24), and the elder brother is told, “this thy brother was dead, and is alive again; and was lost, and is found” (Luke 15:32). The son was dead and lost while he lived, and the father’s speech is not about a corpse. The Lord gives the purpose of His coming in the same terms: “the Son of man is come to save that which was lost” (Matthew 18:11), and “to seek and to save

that which was lost" (Luke 19:10). That which is lost is sought and found. It has not ceased to be.

The point is limited. These verses are about persons in this life, and the parables of Luke 15 are Parable Study territory. They show that the word for lost and perishing is used of a living person in a condition of ruin or distance, and they do not say what becomes of the persons beyond the judgment. The volume draws only the lexical conclusion: the word does not mean cease to be in every verse in which it stands.

3.3 Where the thing destroyed remains

The same is true of things. "Neither do men put new wine into old bottles: else the bottles break, and the wine runneth out, and the bottles perish: but they put new wine into new bottles, and both are preserved" (Matthew 9:17). The bottles perish and the verb is set against being preserved. The skins are burst and useless, and they are there on the ground. In Mark 14 the disciples ask of the ointment, "Why was this waste of the ointment made?" (Mark 14:4), and Matthew puts it, "To what purpose is this waste?" (Matthew 26:8). The word is the noun of the same family, and the ointment was not annihilated. It was poured out.

Peter says that the world that then was "being overflowed with water, perished" (2 Peter 3:6). In the verse before he has said that the earth was "standing out of the water and in the water" (2 Peter 3:5), and in the verse after, the heavens and the earth "which are now" are reserved "unto fire against the day of judgment and perdition of ungodly men" (2 Peter 3:7). The ordered world of that time perished, and the earth remained under the water. The letter names its readers, and the volume reads it so; it is cited here for how the word is used, and the passage is argued by no one in this chapter.

Nations are spoken of in the same way. Pharaoh's servants say to him, "knowest thou not yet that Egypt is destroyed?" (Exodus 10:7), and Egypt was standing. Of Moab the LORD says, "Moab shall be destroyed from being a people" (Jeremiah 48:42), and at the end of the chapter, "Yet will I bring again the captivity of Moab in the latter days" (Jeremiah 48:47). Moab is destroyed as a people and is afterwards brought back from captivity. Hosea says to Israel, "My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge" (Hosea 4:6), and they are still addressed as his people. Paul's word for the discipline of the offender at Corinth is "the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus" (1 Corinthians 5:5). The destruction is of the flesh, and the spirit is saved.

Where what is destroyed or lost remains.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matthew 10:6	But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.	The lost sheep is Israel, who is alive and is sent to.
Luke 15:24	For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found. And they began to be merry.	Dead and lost are said of a son who is alive and speaking.

Verse	KJV text	What to observe
Matthew 9:17	Neither do men put new wine into old bottles: else the bottles break, and the wine runneth out, and the bottles perish: but they put new wine into new bottles, and both are preserved.	The bottles perish and are set against being preserved; they are ruined, not gone.
Exodus 10:7	And Pharaoh's servants said unto him, How long shall this man be a snare unto us? let the men go, that they may serve the LORD their God: knowest thou not yet that Egypt is destroyed?	Egypt is destroyed and is still there.
Jeremiah 48:42	And Moab shall be destroyed from being a people, because he hath magnified himself against the LORD.	Moab is destroyed from being a people, and later restored from captivity.
1 Corinthians 5:5	To deliver such an one unto Satan for the destruction of the flesh, that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord Jesus.	Destruction of the flesh, with the spirit saved.

3.4 Death as a condition

The word for death is used in two ways too. In the garden the word is, “in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die” (Genesis 2:17), and the prophet writes, “the soul that sinneth, it shall die” (Ezekiel 18:4). An annihilationist reads these as the end of life, and the volume grants that they can be read so; Ezekiel 18:4 is among the strongest verses on that side, and it is answered in chapter 8. But the writers of the New Testament speak of death as a state of the living: “you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins” (Ephesians 2:1), and the father’s “was dead, and is alive again” of Luke 15:24 stands beside it. The letter to Ephesus is cited here for the use of the word, and the setting of its readers is not in question.

So death, like destruction, is not one thing in the text. It may be the end of life, and it may be the condition of one who is alive and cut off. A verse that says the wages of sin is death does not say which, and the volume does not read it as if it did.

3.5 What follows, and what does not

Three statements follow, and the volume marks them. It is Stated that destroy, perish, lost and death are used in Scripture of things that cease and of things that remain. It is Shown by the context that the second use is not rare: it occurs in the Gospels, the law, the prophets and the letters, of persons, nations and things. It is Inferred that a destruction verse set beside a judgment after death cannot be read from the word alone, and that the passage and its neighbours have to decide.

Three statements do not follow. It does not follow that the lost do not cease to exist; the chapter has only cleared the ground. It does not follow that the destruction verses are all about ruin; where a verse says a person was put to death, it says so, and the volume does not blur that. And it does not follow that the words of the other side are

weak. Where an annihilationist says that destroy often means kill, he is right, and the cases above are the evidence.

Two neighbours are cited and not repeated. The oracles against the nations, among them Moab, are read in Volume 3 of The Prophets Series, The Nations Judged, with their own question. The Lord's mission to the lost sheep of the house of Israel is read in Volume 2 of the Gospel Commentary Series, The Lord's Ministry to Israel. This chapter takes from them only the use of the words.

The two uses of the words, side by side.

Word	Where it describes an end	Where the thing remains
Destroy	Genesis 7:23; Daniel 2:12; Matthew 12:14	Exodus 10:7; Jeremiah 48:42; 1 Corinthians 5:5
Perish	Numbers 16:33	Matthew 9:17; 2 Peter 3:6
Lost	Not used of the end of a living person in these passages	Matthew 10:6; Luke 15:4, 6, 24, 32; Luke 19:10
Death	Genesis 7:22; Genesis 2:17 on one reading	Luke 15:24; Ephesians 2:1

What the volume takes from the passages

- Destroy and perish describe death in Genesis 7, Daniel 2, Matthew 12 and Numbers 16, and the volume grants it.
- The same words are used of persons who are lost and remain, of things ruined and still there, and of nations destroyed as a people and later restored.
- Death is used of the end of life and of the condition of one who is alive and cut off.
- The word alone does not decide; the passage and its neighbours have to, which is the work of the chapters that follow.

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